

Making a checklist of what you want in a partner

8 findings · 12-step checklist · 1 myth · 5 sources · cheatgrid.com

The list you'd write down and the people you actually fall for come from two different places. A written list doesn't decide who moves you once you meet them.

THE GOAL

You're working out what actually draws you in, using people you've really wanted instead of trait words. Start from **one real name**.

CHECKLIST

Sitting down to write out what you want in a partner, whether that's a dating profile field or telling a friend out loud.

- ☐ Before you write a single trait, write the name or initials of one or two real people you've actually wanted, not an imagined type.
- ☐ Next to each name, **write what actually happened**, like "laughed within five minutes" or "texted back the same day," not a trait word.
- ☐ Start two short lists: what would make you walk away, and what would draw you in.
- ☐ Add to the walk-away list only what you'd genuinely end things over, like cruelty to a stranger or lying about something big.
- ☐ On the draw-in list, write things most people would call good, like being easy to be around, ahead of anything only you'd notice.
- ☐ Cross out anything you wrote mainly because it would **sound good** if someone asked why you picked them.
- ☐ Next to any narrow, specific item, like an exact job title or a niche hobby, write that you're open to being wrong about it.
- ☐ Check both lists against the people you named at the start: cut anything that would have screened out someone who actually pulled at you.
- ☐ Reread the finished list and cut anything you couldn't actually notice within one real conversation.
- ☐ If you're telling this to a friend instead of writing it down, say the walk-away list first, then the draw-in list.
- ☐ Save the list somewhere you'll actually reopen, like your notes app or the profile draft, not just in your head.
- ☐ Date it, so a version from tonight isn't mistaken for one from a year ago.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** If you've been lonely lately, you're more likely than most to wave off a real dealbreaker. You're also more likely to turn away someone who actually has real things going for them, the opposite of what would help.
- 2** Caring more than other people do about a single trait, like ambition or a certain look, barely changes whether you end up liking partners who have more of it, so a single favorite trait isn't worth building the whole list around.
- 3** Your written list doesn't decide whether you like someone once you meet them. Something closer to instinct does that instead.

What you're probably weighing wrong

WATCH

If you've been lonely lately, you're more likely than most to wave off a real dealbreaker. You're also more likely to turn away someone who actually has real things going for them, the opposite of what would help.

In that study, people who scored higher on loneliness accepted real dealbreakers more often, and turned away good matches more often too. [Source 5](#)

DO

Treat something you can't stand as worth more than several things you like. It counts even more if you're picturing this long-term.

People told a bad trait about someone lost interest fast, more than people told several good traits gained it. [Source 5](#)

KNOW

Women's stated answers undersold how much looks moved them, more than men's did. Their real reactions told a different story.

The study asked people to rate a long list of traits they wanted, then checked those ratings against how they responded to someone real. [Source 2](#)

What the list can actually predict, and what it can't

KNOW

A list can never tell you who you'll want. A computer fed a long list about you couldn't guess it.

The lead researcher expected the measures to explain at least some of who wanted whom, and got zero. [Source 1](#)

WATCH

A computer can only spot a general catch. It can't tell you if that person is a catch to you.

General popularity was predictable, but which two people would click was not. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Caring more than other people do about a single trait, like ambition or a certain look, barely changes whether you end up liking partners who have more of it, so a single favorite trait isn't worth building the whole list around.

Across the traits people rated, valuing a trait more than average still barely tracked with who they ended up liking. [Source 2](#)

The preference that decides it once you meet

KNOW

The gap between your list and who you want is never just in your head, real dating research keeps finding it too.

Real daters, tracked by researchers, keep turning out to want people who don't match what they said beforehand. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

Your written list doesn't decide whether you like someone once you meet them. Something closer to instinct does that instead.

Stated wants explain reactions before you meet someone; **unstated, automatic reactions** explain them once you sit down together. [Source 4](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

Men are wired to want a good-looking partner and women are wired to want one with money or status, so those preferences are basically fixed and different between the sexes.

ACTUALLY

A meta-analysis pooling data across dozens of studies found looks moved men's and women's evaluations by about the same amount, and earning potential barely moved either sex's, with **no real difference between them** on either trait. [Source 4](#)

Sources

1. <https://www.sciencedaily.com/releases/2017/08/170830132200.htm>
2. <https://www.psypost.org/the-reality-of-romantic-preferences-large-scale-study-reveals-surprising-truths/>
3. <https://www.sciencenews.org/article/dating-go-round>
4. https://faculty.wcas.northwestern.edu/eli-finkel/documents/2014_EastwickLuchiesFinkelHunt_PsychBull_1_000.pdf
5. <https://www.frontiersin.org/journals/psychology/articles/10.3389/fpsyg.2022.1019272/full>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on What attraction actually runs on at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)